



The Selectboard
TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027

Minutes of the Meeting

Wednesday, April 6, 2026, 7:00 PM
at the Town Hall, 1 South Road

CALL TO ORDER

The meeting was called to order at 7:02 PM

PRESENT: Susan Bronstein (Chair), Scott Johndrow, Jennifer Milikowsky.

PUBLIC COMMENT on any item not on the agenda

Ms. Marilyn Witherell asked about proposed upgrades to the Town Hall Annex. There was brief discussion with no votes taken.

Mr. Steve Holt asked the Selectboard to consider adding the purchase of the proposed police cruiser to a future agenda.

PRESENTATION: Lee Halasz, Conservation Manager, Kestral Trust

Mr. Halasz will present a summary of the Town's Tob Hill / Spruce Hill land acquisition, funded by the Landscape Partnership Grant, and the town's role and obligations moving forward.

Mr. Lee Halasz was present, and provided the town with an update on the project.

He noted that the Conservation Restrictions should be ready for Selectboard review and approval within the next month. Ms. Milikowsky noted that the conservation restrictions do not restrict hunting on the property, and do not impose limits on non-motorized recreation or winter snowmobiling.

Ms. Milikowsky noted that the project is a net-zero cost to the Town. Loss of tax revenue is reported to be just a few hundred dollars per year.

There were a few questions and answers in regard to specific uses on the land. It was noted that the Conservation Commission would be holding a public listening session sometime in May in regard to the draft land management plan, which will then serve to manage all of the town's owned land (about 440 acres).

No action taken.

DISCUSSION: Westhampton Board of Assessors

The Selectboard will engage the Board of Assessors in a conversation about property assessment, and the role assessors have in revenue generation for the town.

Present: Walter Morrey, Marilyn Witherell.

Mr Johndrow began the conversation with questions about how home values are set by the assessors, and how changes to homes (renovations, additions) are assessed and evaluated.

Mr. Morrey provided a basic overview of property assessment, noting that

- Land is assessed separately from structures
- Homes are assessed largely based on the type of structure (saltbox, split-level, ranch, etc.)

- Age of structures, quality of build, quality of materials are all considered.
- Improvements such as new windows, new roof, etc., are also factors.

Ms. Milikowsky asked about the reval process, and how often it is done.

Mr. Morrey noted that that town is required by the state

Every 10 years: to visit every house – as a drive-by, or a home visit.

Every 5 years: the values are assessed by the state.

Every year: properties are assessed based on information that comes in front of the assessors that may change the values.

Mr. Morrey noted that other information – building permit applications, etc. - can trigger referrals to the Assessors, and a reassessment.

Question: when a building is signed off by the building inspector, are the assessors notified?

Answer: Yes, either with receipt of a CO, or notice of a building permit issued.

Ms. Witherell clarified that the town hires a consultant to do annual revals on a case-by-case basis.

Ms. Milikowsky noted a recent case where a home was put up for sale with an asking price much higher than the valuation, and far more significant features that were listed on the Assessors property card. Mr. Morrey noted that he was aware of that particular case.

There was some discussion about the Blueberry Hills subdivision as one example of a ‘neighborhood’ where valuations are considered as a whole. Other neighborhoods include the Pine Island Lake area, gravel and private roads (Rhodes Road, Pisgah Road), with the rest of the town as a fourth ‘neighborhood’.

There was extensive discussion in regard to how one year’s sales data is incorporated into and affects the next year’s valuations.

There was discussion about the impact of the extensive amount of conserved land and its affect on the total capacity of the town to raise and appropriate.

There was further discussion in regard to certain specific assessment practices, and general impacts of reassessments based on recent sales.

There was brief discussion in regard to the process by which requests for abatements are considered.

Mr. Morrey and Ms. Witherell were thanked for their time.

HAZARD MITIGATION PLAN AMENDMENT

The Selectboard will review the final draft amendment to the Westhampton Hazard Mitigation Plan. Votes may be taken.

Mr. Finn noted that the final amendment to the plan needed to be approved by the board, before it could be submitted to MEMA for final approval.

After review, it was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To approve.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (8:04 PM)

COMPLETE STREETS POLICY

The Selectboard will review the final draft of the Complete Streets Policy. Votes may be

taken.

Ms. Bronstein noted a recent question asking ‘why are we taking more work at this time?’ She noted that the policy is intended to qualify the town for grant funding in the future, but should not present an addition to the workload going forward.

There was some discussion relative to the impact of adoption of the policy, and how it might affect operations going forward. Ms. Bronstein and Ms. Milikowsky spoke in favor of the policy, noting that it does not commit the town to pursue any given project, but simply allows for projects to be funded by Complete Streets grants in the future.

It was noted that Complete Streets funding could cover improvement of municipally owned sidewalks, where Chapter 90 (Mass DOT Highway) funding would not.

After further discussion, it was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Bronstein

To approve the policy as presented.

VOTED: 2, 1 (JOHNDROW), 0. (8:19 PM)

BOARD and COMMITTEE REPORTS

Selectboard will receive and act on any board or committee reports or requests.

Recreation

Ms. Dale Kasal noted that the recent CPR class was a significant success.

Ms. Kasal also forwarded a written testimony from a participant who had the unfortunate opportunity to put their training into practice, with a result of the best possible outcome for all involved. The participant acknowledged the skills that she learned having

The board thanked Ms. Kasal and the committee for their work on the program.

Other Reports

Mr. Finn noted written reports received by the Fire Chief and highway superintendent.

DISCUSSION: FY2027 Budget

The board may discuss the FY2027 budget as prepared by the Finance Committee, and the Proposition 2-1/2 override ballot question.

Mr. Finn asked the board if, in the case of a failed override, they would agree to immediately address necessary revisions to the budget prior to submission of such changes to the Finance Committee.

There was discussion as to the role of the Selectboard, the Finance Committee and Town Meeting, the timing of town meeting and town election relative to the potential of an override vote.

The board engaged in a significant discussion about the policy impacts of a failed override, the procedure that should be followed in order to reconsider budget priorities in case of a failed override, etc.

Several hypothetical possibilities were raised. The decision-making process was discussed and debated.

No votes were taken. (9:19 PM)

ADMINISTRATIVE

Review and Act on any Correspondence

A letter from Lyn Newkirk, Business committee chairperson, Mass-Care was reviewed.

A letter from Rep Lindsay Sabadosa congratulating the town on receiving a Green Communities grant.

No action taken.

Review and approval of minutes of past meetings

Minutes of March 23 and March 25 were reviewed.

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To approve the minutes of March 23, 2026 as amended, and March 25, 2026.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:23 PM)

Review and approval of AP and Payroll Warrants (W26-20)

The Accounts Payable and Payroll Warrants were reviewed.

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve Warrants W26-20, WP26-20, and W26-20SUPP as presented.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:24 PM)

MEMBER CONCERNS

Board may discuss new topics raised by individual members, deliberate on potential action or future agenda placement, or give direction to staff.

Mr. Johndrow raised an issue in regard to access to the Town Hall, and the need for activity 'supervision'. Mr. Finn will research potential options to ensure that a 'responsible person' is present at any activity.

Adjourn

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To Adjourn.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:26 PM)

Approved by a vote of the Selectboard at a regular meeting, held on April 20, 2026.

Susan Bronstein

Scott Johndrow

Jennifer Milikowsky